bought 23 pieces from me during his visit. He knew we were struggling and this was his way of helping us. Over the years I took him to visit various fellow craftsmen and he would always buy something as they had given him their time. This was the measure of the man, who in the early eighties became somewhat of a mentor to me on the other side of the Atlantic.

After staying with us, Dale and his wife headed to Scotland, stopping off at Craft Supplies on the way. Nick Davidson agreed to supply products to their son Darrel, to help him set up Craft Supplies USA; this has now become the leading woodturners' supply mail order firm in the USA.

In 1982, a turning event was held at RETOS, a rehabilitation centre in Shannon, where the turning workshop was run by Liam O'Neill. They produced a wide range of products that relied on inserted accessories supplied by Craft Supplies UK. They bought such large quantities that Nick Davison suggested they could supply the Irish woodturners with these products. To launch this initiative, a mini seminar was held over two days, hosting 60 people each day. I started each day off with a demo, followed by other turners including Phil Reardon, Bruce Thompson and Jim Foley. The following year the Irish Woodturners Guild was formed, with Liam O'Neill as its driving force.

1983

Dale Nish invited me to demonstrate at a big wood show in San Francisco, where Craft Supplies USA was launched. The show included some big name furniture guys, as well as turners Dale Nish, Del Stubbs, Gerry Glaser, Jack Daniel and Sid Sharpless, plus Peter Child on the Woodcraft stand. This event was followed by the exceptional experience of demonstrating at the Provo seminar and teaching the first workshop ever held at Craft Supplies.

Del Stubbs – walnut/ desert ironwood box (1981), boxwood flower (1991)

1985

The Arrowmont Symposium was held in 1985, involving all of the leading US names. Mark Lindquist and David Ellsworth had convinced Arrowmont, as the leading woodturning course provider, that they needed to host a such an event. Mick O'Donnell and I attended as delegates, as did a number of other overseas turners; Liam O'Neill was the only overseas presenter.

A major exhibition, *Vision & Concept* was held; I was an invited contributor and it opened gallery doors for me. At the opening of the event, Dick Gerard suggested a national woodturning organisation should be formed. The AAW came into being the following year.

In 1985, I had my first meeting with Bert Marsh, who became my greatest friend and was a most knowledgeable person in the woodturning world. I had a major exhibition at the British Craft Centre; he described my work as 'not bad'. Bert had been dominating the wood show competition scene to such an extent that entries were dropping off and organizers were worried. I suggested they made him a judge, which they duly did and I then had the pleasure of judging countless competitions with him.

1986–87

Seeds were planted for the formation of the AWGB. After the Arrowmont experience, I was determined something needed to happen in the UK. There had been nothing of significance since Parnham House in 1980. I spoke with Mick O'Donnell who was wary, saying we needed an organiser/administrator and funding. In time we got both: Margaret Lester came on board, warning we couldn't pull this off without the help and goodwill of our fellow turners. I invited about twenty turners to a meeting in May, held at our house with Margaret and me jointly chairing. Cecil Jordan, Toby Kaye, Stephen Marchant, Bert Marsh, Dave Regester, Mike Scott, Reg Sherwin, Don White and Mike Cripps were in attendance. At the start it was like treading on egg shells; all seemed wary of one another. Things soon moved on with support and goodwill all round. Sponsorship was obtained from Craft Supplies, Robert Sorby and Rolston Timber. The Crafts Council agreed to underwrite the event against loss.

Margaret's planning and organisation was meticulous. A meeting in June 1987 saw the same group of turners meet again, by this time they were like a band of long lost brothers. As 300 people had told us they wanted to see a national body formed, we agreed to try and launch the AWGB at the seminar. Cecil Jordan drafted the first constitution.

Bert Marsh – Grass Tree Vase

Seminar participants, presented with a *fait accompli*, endorsed the proposal for a national body. We had a committee and chairman willing to stand. We obtained a Secretary and a Treasurer from the floor, namely Hugh O'Neill and Len Grantham. The seminar itself was a great success, with the main presenters being Albert LeCoff, David Ellsworth, Ed Moulthrop, Stephen Marchant, Jim Partridge, Mick O'Donnell and yours truly. Hindsight is a wonderful thing: as organizers, Mick and I probably should not have been demonstrating!

An invited exhibition was staged, including the work by those who had contributed to the growth of the UK turning movement. I entitled the seminar 'From Craft to Art', to which Mike Darlow aired his view that there is no art in woodturning. I think this argument is dead and buried, now that there are so many creative forces out there.

1988

The AAW symposium was held in a down town Philadelphia hotel. It was my pleasure to be a presenter and meet up with so many now established friends. Across town at the Port of History Museum, was an International Exhibition of Lathe-Turned Objects, curated by Albert LeCoff. The most striking developments noted since 1981 were the use of paint, constructed works, mixed materials

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